

The Daily Gamecock: Writer Resources & Prompts

Opinion Section

Spring 2026

This guide helps writers find story ideas, develop angles, and pitch effectively. Use it whenever you're stuck or looking for inspiration.

Finding Your Story

Look Around You

- Focus on things that aren't in the direct spotlight
- Pay attention to what's going on around you every day
- When you see unfairness, think about that as a potential story
- Pay attention to what personally bothers you—those frustrations often resonate with others
- Write about things that are topical and current

Talk to People

- Talk to strangers—you never know what stories they have
- Ask students: What do you go through in your daily life?
- Look for interesting personalities on campus who might submit letters to the editor
- Reach out to student leaders who want to get their own message out

Follow Your Curiosity

- If you keep seeing the same problem, there's probably a story there
- When you hear a rumor, verify it—if true, it could be newsworthy
- Notice patterns: Are multiple students complaining about the same thing?

Political & Civic Angles

Remember

The governor decides how much funding the university gets from the state. State politics directly affect your tuition, your classes, and your campus.

Voter Engagement

- Ask students: Are you registered to vote? Why or why not?
- Investigate voter apathy—what’s causing it?
- What elections are coming up? (local, state, federal)

Policy Impact

- How do state policies directly affect students?
- What’s happening with education funding in South Carolina?
- Are there any bills in the legislature that would impact USC?

Types of Articles

Opinion Pieces

- Take a clear stance on an issue
- Support your argument with facts and examples
- Acknowledge counterarguments but explain why your position is stronger
- End with a call to action or clear conclusion

News Articles

- Present factual information without personal bias
- Include quotes from multiple sources
- Cover the who, what, when, where, why, and how
- Verify all claims before publishing

Features

- Tell a story that goes deeper than breaking news
- Profile interesting people or organizations
- Explore trends or issues over time
- Use narrative techniques to engage readers

Editorials

- How the university handles its own history and state history
- Reflective pieces from seniors looking back on their experiences at USC
- Student leaders who want to share their message

Article Angles Framework

When developing any topic, consider writing it from multiple perspectives:

The “Pro” Angle

- What are the benefits of this policy/trend/decision?
- Who does it help and how?
- What positive outcomes could result?

The “Con” Angle

- What are the drawbacks or risks?
- Who is harmed or disadvantaged?
- What could go wrong?

The “News” Angle

- What are the objective facts?
- What do official sources say?
- What data or statistics are available?

Questions to Ask Yourself

Before Pitching or Writing

Run through this checklist to make sure your story is ready:

1. Why does this matter to USC students right now?
2. Who is affected by this issue?
3. What do I want readers to think, feel, or do after reading?
4. Is this timely? Is there a news hook?
5. Do I have access to sources who can speak on this?
6. Has this been covered recently? If so, what's my new angle?

Sources to Cultivate

- Student Government members
- Club and organization leaders
- Professors in relevant departments
- University administrators and spokespeople
- Local business owners
- Columbia city officials
- State legislators
- Alumni with relevant experience

Quick Story Starters

When you're stuck, try these prompts:

1. What's the biggest complaint you've heard from friends this week?
2. What changed on campus recently that nobody's talking about?
3. What's something everyone assumes is true but might not be?
4. What would you change about USC if you could?

5. What question do new students always ask that has a complicated answer?
6. What's the most unfair thing happening on campus right now?
7. What's an unsung hero or overlooked group on campus?
8. What do students spend money on that they shouldn't have to?
9. What do administrators say vs. what actually happens?
10. What's working really well that nobody gives credit for?

Seasonal & Recurring Topics

Fall Semester

- Back-to-school issues (housing, parking, move-in chaos)
- Football season and game day culture
- Greek life rush and its impact
- Voter registration deadlines
- Halloween (cultural appropriation, fast fashion costumes)

Spring Semester

- Registration for next year's classes
- Housing lottery stress
- Internship and job search season
- Senior reflections and graduation
- Student Government elections

Any Time

- Mental health resources and awareness
- Campus safety and security
- Tuition and financial aid

- Academic advising issues
- Wi-Fi and technology complaints
- Food quality and dining options